



Budget smartphones under ₹20,000 have undergone a seismic transformation in India, evolving from basic utility devices to feature-packed performers. This segment continues to dominate in a price-conscious market like India, but there's a noticeable shift in consumer behaviour as recent data pegs the average selling price of smartphones in India has risen to ₹20,500 (\$248), a 2.8 per cent increase year-over-year, showcasing a shift toward higher-value devices. This price bracket is not without its compromises. However, some phones are breaking the mold in this segment, delivering feature and performance-rich experiences with minimal trade-offs. This evolution highlights a vibrant, fiercely competitive market where innovation trickles down faster than ever. Let's see which phone wins!

Winner: Realme Narzo 70 Turbo

The Realme Narzo 70 Turbo redefines what it means to be a budget smartphone under ₹20,000 in India. While the iQOO Z9 holds the edge in raw GPU performance and gaming benchmarks, the Narzo 70 Turbo has more consistent performance in day-to-day tasks. The OLED display with a 120Hz refresh rate is vibrant and buttery smooth, elevating everything from scrolling to streaming. Its high storage read and write speeds make a tangible difference in app loading times and data transfers, while the long-lasting battery life ensures the phone comfortably lasts through a full day of heavy use. The camera system, while not groundbreaking, delivers impressive results in daylight that punch well above the phone's price tag. Whether you're gaming, working, or simply enjoying media, the

Budget Phone

Pocket-friendly performers



Realme Narzo 70 Turbo
Price: ₹16,999

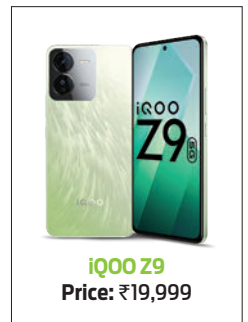


CMF Phone 1
Price: ₹15,999

Narzo 70 Turbo offers an experience that feels far removed from its budget roots, making it the best-performing budget phone of 2024.

Runner-Up: iQOO Z9

The iQOO Z9 is a standout performer in the budget smartphone segment, offering a compelling mix of power and efficiency. It handles multitasking and demanding applications with ease, making it an excellent choice for users who value speed and responsiveness. Its AMOLED display provides punchy colours and smooth visuals, enhancing the experience whether you're gaming, streaming, or scrolling. Gaming enthusiasts will appreciate the Z9's focus on GPU performance, as it delivers fluid gameplay in popular titles without noticeable stutters. The phone also excels in build quality. While it shines in gaming and GPU benchmarks, it falls slightly behind the Realme Narzo 70 Turbo in areas like storage speeds and display brightness. Despite this, the iQOO Z9 remains an exceptional choice for those seeking a budget phone that prioritises raw power and visual flair, offering a well-rounded experience at an attractive price point.



iQOO Z9
Price: ₹19,999

Best Buy: CMF Phone 1

While the CMF Phone 1 doesn't win our performance award, it redefines value in the budget smartphone segment, offering features typically reserved for higher-priced devices. At just ₹15,999, it rivals the performance of phones in the ₹20,000 bracket, delivering exceptional value for money. Powered by the MediaTek Dimensity 7300 processor and equipped with 8 GB of RAM, it ensures a seamless and responsive user experience, handling multitasking and demanding applications with ease. Its unique design, featuring customisable back covers and an Accessory Point for add-ons, sets it apart from competitors, allowing users to personalise their devices to reflect their style. Most importantly, it runs a clean and intuitive version of Nothing OS, providing a bloatware-free environment, which is a rarity at this price.

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